

Session 26: Presence

Key Takeaways

- The presence of God marks his favor toward Israel and becomes the sign of the people's distinctiveness.
- We may think of compassion as being the opposite of judgment, but God's character is holistic and non-contradictory.
- God's presence transforms Israel and, ultimately, everyone.

Eden Restored

The purpose of the tabernacle was the restoration of divine presence ([Exod. 25:8](#)). However, Israel's idolatry jeopardized this plan ([Exod. 33:1-6](#)).

The Most Important Thing

In the dialogue between God and Moses in [Exodus 33:12-17](#), Moses identifies the presence of God as the one essential thing the people cannot move forward without.

God tells Moses, "My presence will go and I will give you (Moses) rest." But Moses responds, "If your presence doesn't go, do not send us up from here." The presence of God is the mark of his favor and the sign of Israel's distinctiveness.

YHWH's Self-Revelation

Exodus 34:6-7 NIV

⁶ And he passed in front of Moses, proclaiming, "The LORD, the LORD, the compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness, ⁷ maintaining love to thousands, and forgiving wickedness, rebellion and sin. Yet he does not leave the guilty unpunished; he punishes the children and their children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation."

This is arguably the most important passage in the Hebrew Bible—the passage most often quoted or alluded to in all of Scripture (20-plus times).

We may think of compassion and judgment as opposites, but YHWH's character is holistic and non-contradictory.

God's patience and justice are held in tension. If we neglect any of these attributes, we end up with a god we've made in our image.

See the [Visual Commentary video](#) for more on this.

The Radiance of Moses

Being in God's presence changes Moses, and his face becomes radiant.

2 Corinthians 3:18 NIV

And we all, who with unveiled faces contemplate the Lord's glory, are being transformed into his image with ever-increasing glory, which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit.

"I am changed in the presence of a holy God."

Altrogge, Mark (1998). "In the Presence."

Reflection Question

How would you describe the interplay between God's compassion and judgment in Exodus?